party lost to a more militant Islamic coalition led by Kashmir-born Nawaz Sharif of Punjab, who replaced her as prime minister. The base of Bhutto's political power was Sind, but until her cordial meeting with Rajiv, many Punjabis of Lahore had also strongly supported Benazir. After a concerted negative campaign against her and her "Mr. 10 Percent" husband, Asif Ali Zardari, who was arrested on charges of corruption, most Pakistanis lost faith in "that Woman." Nawaz, however, proved less capable than Benazir of winning vital international support for Pakistan's deteriorating economy, retaining his power for only a few years before he was removed by Pakistan's president, who brought Benazir back for a second term in 1993.

With the Soviet forces driven out of Afghanistan by then, and no further U.S. funding in the pipeline for Pakistan, Afghanistan reverted to its traditional tribally fragmented feudal state. A new militant force of extremist Muslim "students"—Pashto *ṭālibān*—emerged to take control of Kandahar by the end of 1994, most of them Pathans of former jihadist groups who had lost their financial support.[5] Taliban terrorists with Kalashnikov rifles violently imposed their fundamentalist views of Islamic Sharia law on Afghan women and men, never hesitating to kill those who dared to dispute their authority. Their one-eyed leader, Mullah Omar, ordered the destruction of magnificent gigantic ancient stone Buddhist statues at Bamiyan, which for more than a thousand years had lured tourists from every part of the world to Afghanistan. Benazir supported popular Taliban-run madrassas in Pakistan, all of which paid their own way, mostly through funds from Saudi Arabia. She also urged President Clinton to support the Taliban, who were then competing against Iran's favorite warlords for the control of Afghanistan. Before the end of 1996, Taliban forces had captured Kabul and hanged its former Soviet puppet ruler, Amir Najibullah, while the Tajik warlord Ahmad Shah Masud fled north from that captured capital.

Taliban rule in Afghanistan enforced banning women from public work, closing down every female school and college in Kabul, imposing Islam's veiled dress code on the entire female population, cutting off the hands of thieves, and publicly stoning adulterers. Music was banned from the airwaves and men without beards were subject to arrest. Afghanistan reverted to a medieval Islamic tribal polity. The Uzbek warlord General Rashid Dostum's men joined forces with Masud's Tajiks in opposition, both strongly supported by Russia (after 1990) and India.